constituency until Modi won power in 2014. On his watch, the party has assiduously courted the farming community (see Figure 6.7).

The story of vikas, or development, is even more interesting. In November 2017, then BJP president Amit Shah addressed a press conference at Sindhu Bhawan in Gandhidham, Kutch. The Gujarat assembly elections were just round the corner and the BJP was under pressure. Rahul Gandhi was about to be anointed Congress party chief. Taking him on, Amit Shah told reporters:[19]

The Congress Vice President makes fun of vikas. I challenge Rahul Gandhi to fight in the name of vikas. For Congress, vikas is a joke, for BJP it is an attitude [mizaaj] … The Congress is visible during elections but after elections no one knows where it disappears … Rahul Gandhi comes to Gujarat and makes fun of vikas but the people of Gujarat want answers to these questions from Rahul Gandhi. Why did Congress central governments keep the Narmada project on hold for so long? Why didn't they give permission to put and close doors on the Narmada dam? Why wasn't Kutch given a special desert grant? Why wasn't Gandhinagar given a grant and why did the Congress do an injustice to Gujarat for years in granting crude oil guarantees …

From independence to now, the Congress has deprived the country of vikas, put obstructions in the path of progress and been anti-poor but it comes to Gujarat to ask question of Gujarat's vikas … Gujarat's people want to ask Rahul Gandhi what did you do for Gujarat's development from independence to now? From 2001-2014, under Narendra Modi, the BJP government's time in Gujarat has been Gujarat's golden age. When Rahul Gandhi comes to Gujarat, he should study the statistics on Gujarat's development and not spread lies.

It was typical of the BJP's discourse on development back then. It was aggressive, based on Modi's record in Gujarat and on questioning the Congress. The party was still very focused on its record back then and what it could do in power. It rode to power in 2014 at the Centre on the slogan of vikas. Once the BJP government